



READ IT OUT LOUD

Wait, What?

45 Fun Facts About Animals



0

bones in an
elephant's trunk

3

hearts in an
octopus

7

neck bones in
a giraffe

DAD

carries the baby
seahorses

Fifteen animals, three facts each, and one on every page that is so odd you will want to tell somebody. With a quiz at the back.

Ages 6 to 10 • 28 pages • 15 animals

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How You Can Use This Book

A quick note before you start reading.

Yes, please do

- ✓ Print it as many times as you like for your own children
- ✓ Read it aloud in your classroom or library
- ✓ Photocopy the quiz for every child in the class
- ✓ Print a single page to take on a car journey

Please do not

- ✗ Resell, share or forward the PDF file itself
- ✗ Upload it to any website, group or file sharing service
- ✗ Print it for commercial resale

About the facts. Every fact here is one your child can look up and confirm. Where a number varies in the wild, such as how long a whale grows, the book gives a rounded figure or says roughly, rather than pretending at a precision that does not exist. Nothing has been exaggerated to sound more impressive.

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A Note for Parents

One page, then hand it over.

This is a reading book rather than a worksheet book. Fifteen animals, three facts each, and one fact on every page marked *Wait, what?* because it is the one worth interrupting somebody to share.

Children between about six and ten collect facts the way younger ones collect stones. A fact is a small piece of power. It is something they know that a grown up might not, and being the one who knows it is a genuinely good feeling.

So the design puts the surprising bit first. Every page opens with one number or one word set very large, because that is what gets remembered and repeated. The explanation comes underneath, once curiosity has already been hooked.

Read it in any order. Nothing depends on what came before, and most children will go straight to whichever animal they already like.

There is a quiz at the back with ten questions and an answer page. Try it a week after reading rather than straight away, because that gap is what turns a fact into something that sticks.

"Did you know that?"

Let them tell you the fact even when you already know it. Being the one who explains something is most of the pleasure, and explaining a thing out loud is how a child finds out whether they have really understood it.

Six Ways to Read It

None of them take any longer than just reading it.

1. Read one animal at a time

Three facts is about right for one sitting. The book will still be there tomorrow.

2. Say the big number out loud

Start every page with it. Zero bones. Three hearts. It is the hook.

3. Guess before you read

How many bones do you think are in an elephant's trunk? Guessing first makes the answer land.

4. Look one up together

Pick a fact and go and check it. Learning that facts can be checked is worth more than the fact.

5. Save the quiz

Leave a week before trying it. That gap is what moves a fact into long term memory.

6. Let them retell it badly

A half remembered fact told with enthusiasm is a child who is interested. Correct gently, later.

This one works well in the car. Print two or three pages, hand them over, and you will hear every fact read out to you before the next roundabout.

15 Animals, 45 Facts

Four groups. Read them in any order you like.

On Land

Four legs, and one with none

6

Elephant 7 Giraffe 8 Cheetah 9 Sloth 10

In the Sea

Where the record breakers live

11

Blue Whale 12 Octopus 13 Seahorse 14 Sea Turtle 15

In the Air

Wings, and one that is really a hand

16

Hummingbird 17 Owl 18 Bat 19

Small but Mighty

Tiny, and quietly running the world

20

Ant 21 Honeybee 22 Butterfly 23 Snail 24



The big quiz

page 25

Answers

page 26



4 ANIMALS

On Land

Four legs, and one with none

0

Elephant

7

Giraffe

100

Cheetah

1

Sloth

Everything on these pages walks, climbs or runs. Two of them hold world records: one for being the tallest, one for being the fastest.

Elephant

The biggest animal that walks on land.

0

| bones in a trunk

- 1** An elephant's trunk has no bones in it at all. It is made of muscle, and it can pick up something as small as a single peanut or as heavy as a tree branch.
- 2** Elephants greet each other by touching trunks, a bit like a handshake.
- 3** They flap their enormous ears to cool down. The ears are full of blood vessels close to the skin, so moving air across them cools the blood.

WAIT, WHAT?

An elephant can hear another elephant calling from several kilometres away, partly through the ground with its feet.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Try picking something up using only your arm, with no bones. How would that even work?

Giraffe

The tallest animal in the world.

7

neck bones, same as you

- 1 A giraffe's neck is very long, but it has exactly seven bones in it, which is the same number as in your own neck. The bones are just much bigger.
- 2 Its tongue is dark and about 45 centimetres long, so it can reach round the thorns on an acacia tree.
- 3 Every giraffe has a different pattern of patches, in the same way that every person has different fingerprints.

WAIT, WHAT?

A baby giraffe falls about two metres to the ground when it is born, and is usually standing up within an hour.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Feel the back of your own neck. Seven bones, exactly the same number as a giraffe has.

Cheetah

The fastest animal on land.

100 kilometres an hour

- 1** A cheetah can run at around 100 kilometres an hour, which is faster than a car on a motorway. It can only keep it up for about twenty seconds before it has to stop and rest.
- 2** It cannot roar like a lion. Instead it chirps, rather like a bird.
- 3** The black lines running from its eyes to its mouth work like the black stripes sportspeople paint under their eyes, cutting down the glare of the sun.

WAIT, WHAT?

A cheetah uses its long tail like a rudder, swinging it to turn corners at full speed without falling over.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Time twenty seconds on a clock. That is all the running a cheetah gets before it has to stop.

Sloth

The slowest mammal in the world.

1

trip down the tree a week

- 1** A sloth moves so slowly that green algae grows on its fur. That is helpful, because it makes the sloth harder to spot in the treetops.
- 2** It comes down from its tree only about once a week.
- 3** A sloth can turn its head much further round than you can, which lets it look around without moving its body.

WAIT, WHAT?

Sloths are surprisingly good swimmers, and can move about three times faster in water than they can in a tree.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

What would you do if you only came downstairs once a week?

4 ANIMALS

In the Sea

Where the record breakers live

30

Blue Whale

3

Octopus

DAD

Seahorse

SAME

Sea Turtle

The sea holds the biggest animal that has ever existed, an animal with three hearts, and a father who carries the babies.

Blue Whale

The biggest animal that has ever lived.

30 | metres long

- 1** A blue whale is bigger than any dinosaur ever was. It can grow to about 30 metres, which is roughly the length of three buses parked in a line.
- 2** Its heart is about the size of a small car, and you could crawl through the largest blood vessels.
- 3** It eats krill, which are tiny shrimp-like creatures. It can eat several tonnes of them in a single day.

WAIT, WHAT?

A blue whale's call is louder than a jet engine, and other whales can hear it from hundreds of kilometres away.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Go outside and pace out thirty metres. That is one whale.

Octopus

An animal with three hearts and blue blood.

3

hearts

- 1** An octopus has three hearts. Two pump blood to the gills and one pumps it to the rest of the body.
- 2** Its blood is blue rather than red, because it uses copper to carry oxygen instead of iron.
- 3** It can change both the colour and the texture of its skin in under a second, to match a rock or a patch of sand.

WAIT, WHAT?

An octopus can squeeze its whole body through a gap not much bigger than its eye, because it has no bones at all.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Put your hand on your chest and find one heartbeat. Now imagine listening for three.

Seahorse

The only animal where the father has the babies.

DAD carries the babies

- 1** A female seahorse puts her eggs into a pouch on the father's tummy, and he carries them until they hatch.
- 2** A seahorse has no stomach. Food passes through it so quickly that it has to eat almost constantly.
- 3** It wraps its tail round seagrass to hold on, so that it does not get swept away by the current.

WAIT, WHAT?

Seahorses swim upright, and they are among the slowest swimming fish in the sea.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Which other animals can you think of where the father does most of the looking after?

Sea Turtle

It always comes back to the beach where it hatched.

SAME beach it hatched on

- 1 A female sea turtle swims thousands of kilometres to lay her eggs on the very beach where she herself hatched, sometimes decades earlier.
- 2 Whether a baby turtle is male or female depends on how warm the sand is while the eggs are buried.
- 3 Sea turtles cannot pull their heads inside their shells, unlike the tortoises you see on land.

WAIT, WHAT?

A sea turtle can hold its breath for hours while it is resting on the sea floor.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Could you find your way back to a beach you visited once, years ago, with no map?

3 ANIMALS

In the Air

Wings, and one that is really a hand

BACK

Hummingbird

0

Owl

1

Bat

Flying is rarer than it looks. Only birds, bats and insects truly fly. Everything else that leaves the ground is gliding.

Hummingbird

The only bird that can fly backwards.

BACK

the only bird that flies backwards

- 1 A hummingbird beats its wings so fast that they blur, and that is what makes the humming sound its name comes from.
- 2 It is the only bird that can hover in one spot and fly backwards.
- 3 Its heart beats extremely fast, and it has to eat very often through the day just to keep going.

WAIT, WHAT?

The smallest hummingbird is about five centimetres long, which is shorter than most people's little finger.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Try flapping your arms as fast as you possibly can. A hummingbird is far faster than that.

Owl

It can fly almost completely silently.

0

sound when it flies

- 1** The front edge of an owl's wing feathers is soft and comb-like, which breaks up the sound of the air. That is why an owl can fly so quietly.
- 2** An owl cannot move its eyes in their sockets at all, so it turns its whole head instead, and it can turn it a very long way round.
- 3** Many owls hunt at night and find their food mostly by listening rather than by looking.

WAIT, WHAT?

An owl's ears are at slightly different heights on its head, which helps it work out exactly where a sound is coming from.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Creep across the room without making a sound. Owls do that in mid air.

Bat

The only mammal that can truly fly.

1

| mammal that truly flies

- 1** Plenty of animals glide, but a bat is the only mammal that flaps its wings and properly flies.
- 2** Many bats find their way in the dark by squeaking and listening to the echo. This is called echolocation, and it works a bit like shouting in a tunnel.
- 3** A bat's wing is really a hand. The long thin bones inside it are its fingers, with skin stretched between them.

WAIT, WHAT?

One small bat can eat well over a thousand insects in a single night.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Spread your fingers wide. Now imagine skin stretched between them. That is a wing.

4 ANIMALS

Small but Mighty

Tiny, and quietly running the world

MORE

Ant

8

Honeybee

FEET

Butterfly

1

Snail

The smallest animals in this book do the largest jobs. Without them, a great deal of what you eat would simply stop growing.

Ant

It can carry many times its own weight.

MORE ants than people, by a long way

- 1** An ant can lift and carry something a good deal heavier than itself. If you could do the same, you would be picking up a small car.
- 2** Ants live in colonies, and every ant has a job. Some look after the eggs, some find food, and some defend the nest.
- 3** They leave a scent trail behind them so the other ants can follow the path to food.

WAIT, WHAT?

There are far more ants on Earth than there are people, by an enormous margin.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

How heavy is the heaviest thing you can lift? Now imagine lifting something much heavier than yourself.

Honeybee

It dances to tell the others where the flowers are.



the shape of its dance

- 1** When a honeybee finds flowers, it flies home and dances in a figure of eight. The angle and the length of the dance tell the other bees which direction to fly and how far.
- 2** Bees make honey from flower nectar, and a single bee makes only a very small amount in its whole life.
- 3** Bees see colours differently from us. They cannot see red, but they can see patterns on flowers that are invisible to our eyes.

WAIT, WHAT?

Almost every third mouthful of the food people eat depends on bees and other pollinators visiting flowers.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Try giving somebody directions across the room without speaking, only by moving.

Butterfly

It tastes with its feet.

FEET is what it tastes with

- 1** A butterfly has taste sensors on its feet, so it lands on a leaf to find out whether it is the right plant to lay eggs on.
- 2** It drinks through a long tube called a proboscis, which curls up neatly like a party blower when it is not being used.
- 3** A butterfly starts life as a caterpillar, then rebuilds itself completely inside a chrysalis.

WAIT, WHAT?

Monarch butterflies migrate thousands of kilometres, and no single butterfly lives long enough to make the whole round trip.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

Imagine tasting your dinner through your feet. What would you definitely not want to stand on?

Snail

It carries its house on its back.

1

foot, and it never stops

- 1** A snail glides along on a single muscular foot, laying down slime as it goes. The slime is so protective that a snail can crawl over the edge of a blade of grass unharmed.
- 2** Its shell grows with it, spiralling outwards, so a snail never needs to move house.
- 3** Snails have tiny teeth arranged in rows on a ribbon-like tongue, and there can be thousands of them.

WAIT, WHAT?

If the weather turns too dry, a snail can seal itself into its shell and wait, sometimes for a very long time.

TRY THIS, OR TALK ABOUT IT

What would you take with you if you carried your house everywhere?

Ten Questions

Try it a week after reading rather than straight away. Tick one circle for each.

1 How many bones are there in an elephant's trunk?

- ☐ a. None at all ☐ b. Twelve ☐ c. Over a hundred
-

2 How many bones are in a giraffe's neck?

- ☐ a. Seven, the same as yours ☐ b. Twenty ☐ c. Forty two
-

3 How many hearts does an octopus have?

- ☐ a. One ☐ b. Two ☐ c. Three
-

4 Which parent seahorse carries the babies?

- ☐ a. The mother ☐ b. The father ☐ c. Both together
-

5 What does a butterfly taste with?

- ☐ a. Its wings ☐ b. Its feet ☐ c. Its antennae
-

6 Why can an owl fly so quietly?

- ☐ a. It is very light ☐ b. Soft comb-like wing feathers ☐ c. It holds its breath
-

7 Which of these is the only mammal that truly flies?

- ☐ a. A flying squirrel ☐ b. A bat ☐ c. An owl
-

8 What is a bat's wing really?

- ☐ a. A hand ☐ b. A tail ☐ c. A giant ear
-

9 What shape does a honeybee dance to give directions?

- ☐ a. A circle ☐ b. A figure of eight ☐ c. A straight line
-

10 Where does a female sea turtle lay her eggs?

- ☐ a. Anywhere convenient ☐ b. The beach where she hatched ☐ c. On floating seaweed
-

How Did You Do?

Every answer is on the page for that animal, so go back and check any that surprised you.

- | | | |
|----|--|---------------------------------|
| 1 | How many bones are there in an elephant's trunk? | a. None at all |
| 2 | How many bones are in a giraffe's neck? | a. Seven, the same as yours |
| 3 | How many hearts does an octopus have? | c. Three |
| 4 | Which parent seahorse carries the babies? | b. The father |
| 5 | What does a butterfly taste with? | b. Its feet |
| 6 | Why can an owl fly so quietly? | b. Soft comb-like wing feathers |
| 7 | Which of these is the only mammal that truly flies? | b. A bat |
| 8 | What is a bat's wing really? | a. A hand |
| 9 | What shape does a honeybee dance to give directions? | b. A figure of eight |
| 10 | Where does a female sea turtle lay her eggs? | b. The beach where she hatched |

Eight or more? That is a very good score. **Fewer than five?** It only means the book is worth reading again, which is not a bad outcome for a book.

45

C E R T I F I C A T E

Official Fact Collector

This certificate is proudly given to

for reading all 45 facts in this book, for knowing how many bones are
in an elephant's trunk, and for telling at least three other people
about the octopus.

Date

Grown up signature





**A fact you can tell somebody is a fact
you will keep.**



That is why this book is written to be read out loud. Every page has something worth interrupting a grown up for, and the interrupting is the point.

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